

The biggest advantage that an application can get by going open source is the sheer bounty of talent in the form of thousands of developers who dedicate time and grey matter to simplify and/or improve the application. Another major advantage PHP enjoys is that it's extremely light on system resources.

Another way of looking at PHP's popularity is the growing number of Web sites. A site today is very different from a site of a few years ago, simply because of its users. A typical user is not satisfied with an ordinary site with some text and pictures. He wants something attention-grabbing, something that serves not only his purpose, but also makes browsing fun. Animations and interactivity form a large part of that fun factor, and coding in PHP is simple—you can achieve a lot more with fewer lines of code.

PHP code is similar in syntax to Perl and C. For those not interested in getting too much into coding, there are PHP-based CMSes (Content Management Systems) available, like PHP-Nuke, which don't require the user to have any programming knowledge. However, the flexibility of PHP cannot be denied, and all that PHP-Nuke allows is basic Web page manipulation, so we shall refrain from such front-end efforts. The basic purpose of PHP is server-side coding, so let's get down to it!